

A victor has emerged

QUITE OFTEN, WE SEE THAT THE INDIVIDUALS AND COMPANIES THAT MOST INDULGE IN VIRTUE SIGNALLING ARE, IN REALITY, THE BIGGEST HYPOCRITES.

Companies like to tout about their massive contributions towards reducing the carbon footprint of their offices and products but they can be easily called out for doing the exact opposite. You can't blame businesses for wanting to keep their bottom line high and their top line even higher. You'll have companies using recycled plastic, not because it's the right thing to do but there are subsidies attached to the use of recycled plastic and there's also the fact that it's often cheaper.

Then there are companies that purposefully do not offer a charger with the product but have it as a purchasable accessory. Why? Because the environment would be better off with reduced amounts of e-waste being dumped into bottomless waste pits. And when you do have to purchase the charger, you'll be given a proprietary interface which can only be used with said device and nothing else. Of course, it's much cheaper to simply use a widely accepted standard that more than 82 per cent of the industry uses but where's the fun in that? You can't make money off of expensive proprietary chargers, nor can you make money off of flimsy charging cables that use proprietary interfaces. Oh, and let's not forget about the numerous dongles that can be sold to pad the bottom line because none of the standard interfaces can ever be used.

Apple supposedly made nine billion dollars by not providing earphones and chargers with their new iPhones. The folks over at 'CSS Insight', the analyst firm that came up with the 'nine billion dollar' figure argue that Apple could be saving about ₹2.6K per iPhone sold. And when they were running these numbers, Apple had already sold close to 190 million iPhones. It could be argued that Apple did indeed save a lot of money but considering that they use a proprietary charger and the cable used is also very flimsy, countless customers would have been forced to buy a charger and cable anyway.

Unfortunately, there have been several bumps along the way for the company as several countries enacted laws forcing the company to provide chargers with iPhones for units being sold in said countries. And with the latest ruling from the EU, it seems like the end of the lightning connector is near. The European Parliament and a lot of EU member countries still need to sign off on the provisionally approved agreement which will force companies to offer USB Type-C interfaces for charging their devices. Since the only company that's using a proprietary interface in this day and age for their smartphones is Apple, this would seem like a huge blow to the company. As per the announcement, EU consumers stand to save about 250 million Euros or ₹2085 Crores.

It's very unlikely that we'll get iPhones with USB Type-C interfaces outside the EU unless more governments enact similar laws. However, the move to unify standards also presents some challenges to power-hungry devices. Laptops are also supposed to transition towards using USB Type-C interfaces for charging. The deadline for laptops is not until 2026 so there's still time. However, considering how high-performance laptops have been getting more and more power-hungry, it would be interesting to see how manufacturers react. Current USB PD standards offer up to 240 Watts to be pushed via a single interface. And processors and graphics cards have individually started creeping towards higher wattage. Who knows, we might end up with gaming laptops running off of one or two USB PD ports or manufacturers might take a call to not push the processor and graphics cards to ridiculous power levels.

It would seem that being restricted to using a common USB Type-C interface might get device manufacturers to be creative and innovate more. They'll have to figure out new power profiles, better cooling mechanisms, better power management algorithms and more. And the best part is that having a single interface will actually result in companies being more environment-friendly. At least now they'll stop being hypocrites. **d**



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